

INDUSTRIAL DESIGNER

Dieter Rams

Weniger, aber besser.

LESS, BUT BETTER.



BORN	20 May 1932, Wiesbaden, Germany
EDUCATION	Wiesbaden School of Art
AT BRAUN	1955 – 1997
NATIONALITY	German

BIOGRAPHY

Architect of Quiet Objects

Dieter Rams is one of the most influential product designers of the twentieth century. His work at Braun — spanning over four decades — produced some of the most enduring objects in design history.

Born in Wiesbaden in 1932, Rams trained as an architect and interior designer before joining Braun in 1955, where he would eventually rise to become head of design. Alongside his work at Braun he simultaneously ran the design department of Vitsoë, the furniture company, from 1959 onwards.

His belief that good design should be invisible — serving the user without demanding attention — shaped not only his own practice, but the broader trajectory of industrial design. His work influenced a generation of designers, most notably Jonathan Ive and the design language of Apple.

Since retiring from Braun in 1997, Rams has continued to advocate for sustainable, considered design through lectures, exhibitions, and his ongoing relationship with Vitsoë.

DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

Ten Principles for Good Design

In response to the question — "Is my design good design?" — Rams developed ten principles that remain the most concise articulation of design ethics ever written.

01

Good design is innovative

The possibilities for innovation are not, by any means, exhausted. Technological development is always offering new opportunities for innovative design. But innovative design always develops in tandem with innovative technology, and can never be an end in itself.

02

Good design makes a product useful

A product is bought to be used. It has to satisfy certain criteria, not only functional but also psychological and aesthetic. Good design emphasises the usefulness of a product whilst disregarding anything that could possibly detract from it.

03

Good design is aesthetic

The aesthetic quality of a product is integral to its usefulness because products we use every day affect our person and our well-being. But only well-executed objects can be beautiful.

04

Good design makes a product understandable

It clarifies the product's structure. Better still, it can make the product talk. At best, it is self-explanatory.



05

Good design is unobtrusive

Products fulfilling a purpose are like tools. They are neither decorative objects nor works of art. Their design should therefore be both neutral and restrained, to leave room for the user's self-expression.

06

Good design is honest

It does not make a product more innovative, powerful or valuable than it really is. It does not attempt to manipulate the consumer with promises that cannot be kept.

07

Good design is long-lasting

It avoids being fashionable and therefore never appears antiquated. Unlike fashionable design, it lasts many years — even in today's throwaway society.

08

Good design is thorough down to the last detail

Nothing must be arbitrary or left to chance. Care and accuracy in the design process show respect towards the consumer.

09

Good design is environmentally friendly

Design makes an important contribution to the preservation of the environment. It conserves resources and minimises physical and visual pollution throughout the lifecycle of the product.

10

Good design is as little design as possible

Less, but better — because it concentrates on the essential aspects, and the products are not burdened with non-essentials. Back to purity, back to simplicity.



Objects That Endure

From consumer electronics to furniture systems, each object was designed to be used, understood, and kept. A selection of the most significant work from a 42-year career at Braun and Vitsoë.

ALL

BRAUN

VITSOË

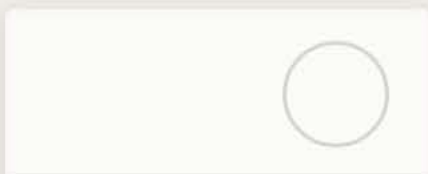


BRAUN

T3 Pocket Radio

1958

The T3 pocket radio introduced what would become a signature of Rams's work: the grid. A simple perforated speaker grille and a sliding power switch distilled AM radio to its essence. Later cited by Jonathan Ive as a direct inspiration for the original iPod.

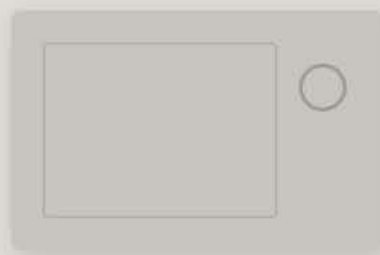


BRAUN

SK4 Phonosuper

1956

Designed with Hans Gugelot, the SK4 — nicknamed "Snow White's Coffin" for its clear acrylic lid — was among the first consumer electronics to use transparent materials. It dismantled the idea that machines must look industrial.

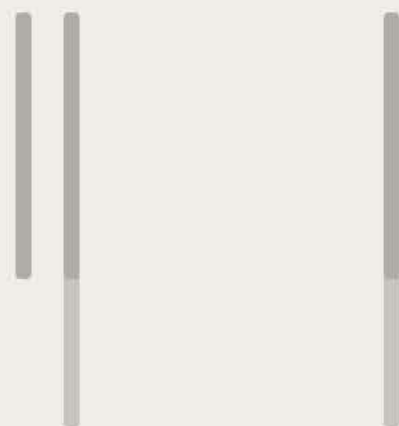


BRAUN

T 1000 World Receiver

1963

A professional-grade shortwave radio that became an icon of the Braun system: every element arranged with mathematical precision, every knob and dial given exactly the weight it deserved — no more, no less.



VITSŒ

606 Universal Shelving System

1960

Perhaps the most radical shelving system ever conceived. The 606 uses a wall-mounted E-track that allows any configuration to be assembled, disassembled, and reassembled infinitely. Still manufactured without alteration today.

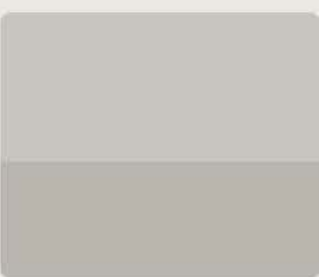


BRAUN

ET 66 Calculator

1987

The colour-coded keypad of the ET 66 — grey for numbers, red for equals, black for operations — is a masterclass in communicating function through colour without decoration. The layout was adapted almost directly into iOS's Calculator app.



VITSŒ

620 Chair Programme

1962

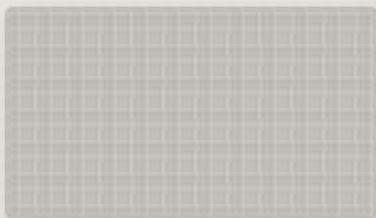
An injection-moulded modular seating system that allows chairs, sofas, and loungers to be reconfigured by swapping interchangeable seat, back, and arm units. Designed to last generations, not seasons.



BRAUN

AB 312 Alarm Clock

1987



BRAUN

L2 Speaker

1958

INFLUENCE & LEGACY

A Philosophy That Persists



Apple & Jonathan Ive

Jonathan Ive, Apple's longtime Chief Design Officer, has repeatedly cited Rams as his primary influence. The original iMac, iPod, and iPhone all bear direct formal relationships to Braun products of the 1960s and 70s. Rams himself acknowledged the connection with quiet pride.



Education & Curriculum

The Ten Principles are taught in design schools globally and have become the closest thing industrial design has to a universal ethical framework. A generation of designers — from product to UX to interaction — were educated through the lens of these ten ideas.



Museum Collections

Works by Rams are held in the permanent collections of MoMA New York, the Victoria and Albert Museum London, the Design Museum London, the Vitra Design Museum, and dozens more institutions worldwide. He is among the most collected industrial designers in history.



Sustainability Advocacy

Long before sustainability became a design industry keyword, Rams argued that good design is inherently ecological — that objects should be built to last, repaired, and passed on. His Principle 9 anticipated the circular economy movement by decades.



Rams (2018 Film)

Director Gary Hustwit's documentary *Rams* brought his philosophy to a new generation, exploring not only his design legacy but his deep concern for overconsumption and environmental sustainability. The film prompted a renewed global conversation about what design is for.



Vitsoe Today

The 606 Universal Shelving System and 620 Chair Programme remain in continuous production, manufactured in exactly the form Rams designed them. Vitsoe's ethos of "living better, with less, that lasts longer" is a direct expression of Rams's philosophy, still relevant sixty years on.

TIMELINE

A Life in Design

1932

Born in Wiesbaden

20 May 1932. His grandfather, a carpenter, teaches him the value of craft and the discipline of making things well.

1947

Wiesbaden School of Art

Studies architecture and interior design, interrupted by a practical apprenticeship as a carpenter.

1955

Joins Braun

Hired as an architect to redesign Braun's Frankfurt offices. His talent is quickly recognised and he moves into product design.

1956

SK4 Phonosuper

Co-designs the SK4 with Hans Gugelot. The clear acrylic lid and flat white case become a declaration of intent for the entire Braun design programme.

1960

606 Shelving System

Designs the 606 Universal Shelving System for Vitsoë, beginning a long parallel relationship with the furniture company.

1960

606 Shelving System

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1961

Head of Design at Braun

Appointed Director of Design, a role he would hold for three decades and use to build one of the most coherent and consistent design programmes in corporate history.

1976

Ten Principles

Articulates his ten principles of good design, providing the field with its most enduring ethical framework.

1997

Retires from Braun

Leaves Braun after 42 years. His design language at the company had by this point been largely abandoned in favour of market-driven aesthetics — a development he viewed with evident sadness.

2018

Rams Documentary

Gary Hustwit releases *Rams*, a film documenting his life and philosophy. The film introduces his work to a new generation and sparks renewed interest in his legacy.

Now

Ongoing Advocacy

Continues to lecture and write on design, sustainability, and the role of the designer in a world overwhelmed by objects. The 606 and 620 remain in production, unchanged.